as a "forgiving" zone permeably overlapping both the westernmost reaches of the Indic sphere and the eastern peripheries of the Persianate. But this borderland location combined with their own life-world along the nomad–urban continuum, creating palpable socio-political, linguistic (cf. above), cultural, and even epistemological distances between them and – to adapt Ernest Gellner's term – the "Great Tradition" of Perso-Islamic elite lifeways.[32] Indeed, as further discussed in Chapter 2, the topographic and ecological realities of the region of Ghur apparently compounded these *conceptual* (rather than physical) distances from the Persianate ecumene, though in the end both the tangible and the *in*tangible spaces were surmountable.

As also described in detail in the Chapter 2, the Ghuris (and among them the pre-imperial Shansabanis) were probably exposed to localized practices of Islam – perhaps even observing some of its religious mores – by the later eleventh century, if not before. It will be further argued that, in tandem with their gradual but discernible rise to regional prominence or "incipient" kingship, the early Shansabanis *overtly* adopted the trappings of Islamic confessionalism – part of the "playbook" of kingship prevalent in their specific milieu – in the first three or four decades of the twelfth century. Perso-Islamic patterns of kingship were initiated and sustained throughout the region *via* the precedents set by the Ghaznavids and reinforced by the Saljuqs – between whose territorial ambitions fell the home regions of the emerging Shansabanis (map, p. xv). Due to this serendipitous location, the Shansabanis were cast in the role of inheritors and eventual contributors to these rich cultural landscapes. In keeping with the above-described, overlapping spheres of activity that permitted the entry of outsiders into the complex of Perso-Islamic kingship, the beginnings of the Shansabanis' Islamic confessionalism were perceptibly declared – and thus retrievable by later investigators – by means of their *patronage* of architectural as well as other types of cultural production (cf. esp. Chapters 2 and 3).

A century or so before the recordable emergence of the Shansabanis – just after the establishment of the Ghaznavids (see below) – the Saljuqs had entered Persianate frames of reference. Sources generally from outside the Arabic–Persian scholarly traditions candidly assessed the eponymous Saljuq ibn Duqaq's embrace of Islam as part of a "design of conquest in the Muslim world": the historical texts' prevarications regarding the reasons behind Saljuq's fateful choice might have served as historiographical synecdoche of the western Turkic populations' uneven Islamic conversions as they encountered Islamic socio-religious practices filtering eastward along the byways of commerce, and met with again *via* the Saljuqs' own westward migrations.[33] Although the specific details remain conjectural, Islamic confessionalism and its manifestations became incumbent upon the Saljuqs as they entered the Persianate realms. In AH 431/1040 CE, the